

Week 11: Dialogue

(Communicating effectively in the workplace)

Communication in English IV
(GST 203)



**SCHOOL OF
MEDIA AND
COMMUNICATION**
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Learning Outcomes

- ♥ By this end of this session, students should be able to:
 - Appreciate the contextual factors that shape business conversations
 - Understand the difference between monologues and dialogues and the purpose of having dialogues
 - Have effective business conversations that prioritize active listening, respect and thoughtfulness
 - Minimize obstacles to effective dialogue

Understanding Workplace Communication

- ❖ Workplace communication is communication by people who work in an organization.
- ❖ It could be ***internal*** communication or ***external*** communication.

Understanding Workplace Communication

- ❖ While ***internal communication*** involves communication by employees and employers in an organization, ***external communication*** involves people who work for a particular organization and people who do not operate within that organization but have some sort of impact (no matter how small) on the organization.
 - For example, communication with the company's customers, potential clients, suppliers, government regulatory authorities, media personnel, etc. will be termed external communication.

Understanding Workplace Communication

❖ Workplace communication can be:

- **Formal:** Conversation between staff and a visitor, between staff and a customer, performance evaluation session between manager and subordinate, management meetings, etc.
- **Informal:** A mentoring session, colleagues getting together after work, etc.

Workplace Communication Examples

- ❖ Weekly departmental meetings
- ❖ Telephone conversation between employee and supplier
- ❖ Telephone conversation between colleagues
- ❖ Sales pitch
- ❖ Meet and greet with peers in the industry
- ❖ Banter between colleagues
- ❖ Job interview at an organization
- ❖ Lunch meeting with partners
- ❖ Lunch meeting with colleagues/superiors
- ❖ Company-wide town hall meeting
- ❖ Management meeting
- ❖ Board of Directors' meeting
- ❖ Shareholders' meeting
- ❖ Conferences

Context matters

- ❖ Each communication context requires a different kind of skill.
 - If you are having lunch with a colleague, the conversation tends to be more relaxed. You can crack jokes and talk about shared interests.
 - If you're presenting a report to your supervisor, you will need to be more formal and focus solely on presenting the report in the best possible way. You will also avoid making unnecessary jokes and unnecessary mistakes.

Case Study 1: You smell nice!

- ❖ A story went viral, last year, about a young applicant who lost a job opportunity because he “innocently” complimented his interviewer by telling her that she smelled nice.
- ❖ Was he wrong to have complimented his interviewer? Why?



Why it's important to be good at communication in the workplace (1)

♥ **Every conversation is an opportunity to present yourself in the best possible light.**

- Each individual has a personal identity that shines through in conversations with other people.
- What are you communicating about yourself?
- Do you communicate confidence, brilliance, dependability?
- Or does your disposition and your communication present you as a dull, boring, unintelligent person who is not good at his work?
- Find out what your tone and the way you engage in conversations says about you.

- ♥ When, for example, you say, “I don’t know” a lot, you communicate that you are a clueless person.
- ♥ Nothing wrong with sometimes not knowing, but when it happens all the time, perhaps you need to interrogate yourself a bit more.
- ♥ A lot of times, we say “I don’t know” because we *don’t want to* interrogate ourselves or find answers/solutions to questions.



- ❖ At the workplace, you should be a **solutions provider**, not a clueless person, *not just “one other addition to the team”*.
- ❖ Your presence should add value.
- ❖ Add value through the perspectives you bring in your conversations.



Why it's important to be good at communication in the workplace (2)

- ❖ It's not only important that you represent yourself in the best possible light.
- ❖ You need to represent your organization in the best way possible, whether at an industry event, or a sales event, or in a business meeting with another organization.
- ❖ Protect the company brand.

It's all about building lasting relationships

- ❖ Every conversation is an opportunity to build a relationship.
- ❖ Do not destroy a good relationship or an opportunity for a good relationship because you did not do your homework or failed to immerse yourself in the conversation.

Quick exercise: Self-reflection

- ❖ Does your presence add value, or are you just one of the numbers?
- ❖ Can you identify three specific ways that you add value in your class, at home, or in any other group you belong to?

Engaging in dialogues

- ❖ One of the ways of communicating in the workplace is by engaging in **dialogues**.
- ❖ This is opposed to monologue, which can be described as talking **at** other people.
- ❖ Dialogue is conversation between two or more persons; it involves talking **with** other people.

The purpose of dialogues

- ♥ The purpose of engaging in dialogue is to reach a **mutual understanding** or **shared meaning**.
 - The person you are dialoguing with *does not necessarily need* to AGREE with you, but they *need* to UNDERSTAND you.
- ♥ With monologue on the other hand, you're just concerned with passing on information or an idea.

Dialogue between manager and employee

Manager: What progress have you made on the inventory report?

Employee: It's almost ready. I only have one section to complete.

Manager: *Good.* Do you see any problem with getting it all wrapped up by tomorrow afternoon?

Employee: No, not if you need it by then.

Manager: *Yes,* I need it by three p.m. tomorrow at the latest.

Employee: You can count on that.

Note:

- *The manager learned of the state of the report.*
- *The employee was given the chance to report any challenges.*
- *Time factor/constraint was discussed.*
- *There was an agreement/informal contract.*
- *A bond of trust and commitment was created.*

Video: Monologue or Dialogue?

Pause at this point and watch this video by Communication Coach Alex Lyon on the difference between monologue and dialogue. Think about what this means for communication in the workplace.

The video is titled “Workplace Communication Skills: Monologue or Dialogue?” You can find the link on elearning (Week 4), or you can watch it on this link:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wPdXdjK1rW8>

When can we say that dialogue is effective?

Effective dialogue

- ❖ Dialogue is effective when the two parties involved reach a *shared understanding*.
 - i.e. they understand each other as well as possible
 - They don't necessarily have to agree; all that is required for dialogue to be effective is for understanding to be mutual.



How do you achieve effective
dialogue?

1. Be clear about your purpose/intention

- ♥ What do you want to achieve with the conversation?
- ♥ Be clear.
- ♥ Be specific.
- ♥ Don't beat around the bush.
- ♥ Don't waste people's time.
- ♥ Think through the conversation. Prepare for it if you have enough time.

2. Organize your thoughts carefully

- ❖ Do not provide too much information at once.
- ❖ Break up dialogue with demonstration.
 - Think of this as you would an essay – introduce a topic sentence and provide supporting details.
 - Be sure to include examples and illustrations that help your listener get your point.

3. Use positive and clear language

- ❖ Do not use negative language.
 - Do not say, “I will not be able to do this until Wednesday.” Say, “*I will be able to work on this by Wednesday when I complete my current task.*” Or, “*Do you mind if I work on this when I complete my current task on Wednesday?*”
 - Do not say, “I cannot help you.” Say something like this: “*I would like to help you, but I am rather constrained at the moment.*”
- ❖ Do not insult people. Be respectful. Be courteous.
- ❖ Choose the simplest, clearest words possible that convey your intended meaning. Don’t try so hard to impress that you obfuscate.

4. Be sincere

♥ Be sincere.

- Say only what is true. Remember that you are building your personal identity. What do you want people to remember you as?
- Also, learn to know when people are not being sincere.

Gauging other people's sincerity

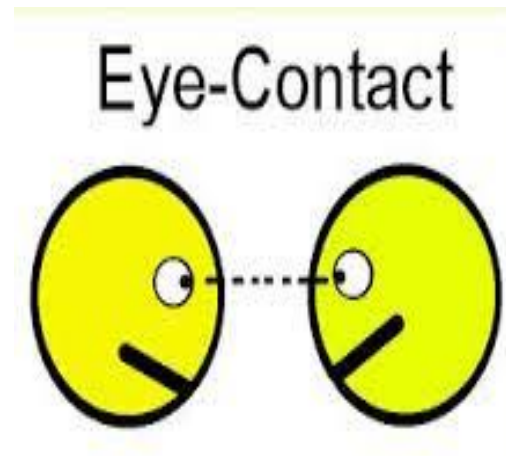
- ♥ It's also important to gauge the energy of the people we're conversing with and know when they are lying to us or just flattering us.
- ♥ This would mean being self-aware and knowing how to sift through people's words, what Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie calls having a **fantastic bullshit detector**.
- ♥ Things to watch out for:
 - Inconsistency in speech
 - Too much gesture: people often gesture a lot to conceal tension
 - Unsteady voice
 - Facial expression: avoidance of eye contact, weird movement of the eyes, lips, excessive batting of eyelids
 - Excessive sweating

5. Listen actively

- ♥ Effective dialogue is a two-way thing.
 - You're not just giving orders or dumping information.
 - The other person has to react in some way.
- ♥ So, listen. Listen attentively.
 - Give ***respectful*** and ***undivided attention*** to the speaker.
 - Ask questions.
 - Do not just listen to respond. ***Listen to understand.***
 - Listen to the emotions behind spoken words.
- ♥ Interpret body language. What is the other person saying with his/her disposition and body?

Tips for active listening

- ❖ Tilt towards the speaker.
- ❖ Maintain eye contact.
- ❖ Make the person comfortable with a smile.
- ❖ Avoid distractions.
- ❖ Be careful with your body position/language.



Tips for active listening

- ♥ Listen first; speak later.
- ♥ Interrupt only when you need clarification on something.
 - Don't just interrupt because something came to mind and you are dying to chip it in.
- ♥ Encourage the other person to speak.
- ♥ Do not be overtly time-conscious. This could be distracting.

6. When possible, research

- ❖ For dialogue to be effective, you need to know the person you are conversing with.
- ❖ So, if you have enough time, do a *background check* before you start that conversation.
- ❖ It may be important to answer the following questions before commencing the conversation:
 - Who is the person before me?
 - What is the person's opinion on the issue at stake?
 - What will be the impact of what we will discuss on his/her work?
 - What is the person's emotional and psychological state?

Other tips for effective dialogue

- ❖ Do not dominate the conversation. Nobody should.
- ❖ Say what you really mean.
- ❖ Speak to elicit reaction from the listener. Remember, it's not a monologue.
 - Ask questions.
 - Prompt the other person to say something.

Eliminating obstacles to effective dialogue

- ❖ There could be psychological obstacles to effective dialogue, like doubt, fear, lack of trust, feeling of intimidation, guilt, inferiority complex, etc.
- ❖ There could also be other external obstacles like phone/internet distractions, sound, physical distance, difference in class, accent/jargon/slang, faulty equipment, cultural differences, etc.

Eliminating obstacles to effective dialogue

- ♥ Try to eliminate obstacles by focusing on the aim of the dialogue.
 - Why is this conversation so necessary?
 - How does it impact you, your organization?
 - How does your undivided attention benefit the other person?

- ♥ Minimize physical distractions by putting them out of the way. E.g. Turn off your phone or set in on silent mode.

On the importance of research/
background check:
Case studies

Case Study 2: Recruiting Phil

Jon, a senior vice president of Globetrot Consulting, was assigned the task of meeting and possibly recruiting Phil, a successful consultant working for a competing firm. Jon had heard from a former client that Phil wasn't happy with his current situation and that he was looking for something new. Since Phil was well thought of in corporate circles, Jon called him and the two arranged to meet for lunch the next week.

Jon learned as much as he could about Phil in the days before their meeting. He learned that Phil had earned an M.B.A. in 1998 from Old Ivy, a first-tier school; had joined a Fortune 500 company as a strategic planner upon graduation; and had worked for two major consulting firms in strategy since then. Jon had also exploited his corporate network to gather insights from Phil's former clients. All in all, Jon managed to learn quite a bit about this prospective recruit.

Case Study 2: Recruiting Phil

What Jon didn't know was what Phil thought about Globetrot Consulting. Had their paths ever crossed? Had Globetrot interviewed Phil during his final year as an M.B.A. student back in 1988, or again when he switched from industry to consulting? Had Globetrot ever offered employment to Phil? Jon called his human resource department to get the answers.

While he waited, Jon turned to other sources. Since management consulting is a small, almost inbred profession, he figured that someone in the firm must know Phil. He therefore put out a confidential inquiry within the firm: "Who knows this guy?" He also checked with the many firm members who were alumni of Old Ivy's M.B.A. programme.

Case Study 2: Recruiting Phil

Within a few days, he had responses from the human resource department and from three Globetrot employees who personally knew Phil. Human Resources reported interesting news. The firm had made a job offer to Phil back in 1988, when he graduated from Old Ivy, but he had turned it down to go into industry. Globetrot had made him another offer in 1992, when he first went into consulting, with the same negative result.

This was interesting information. Did Phil have a negative view of the firm? What was the issue? Jon's phone calls to colleagues who knew Phil answered these questions. "Yes, I know Phil fairly well," said a former Old Ivy classmate. "He's never taken our firm seriously because he thinks that we're not fully competitive in strategic planning." Other contacts related much the same story.

Case Study 2: Recruiting Phil

Jon was now much better prepared for his one-on-one meeting with Phil. He knew Phil's background and Phil's perception of Globetrot Consulting. When the two met the next week, Jon was totally prepared to talk about Globetrot's growing strength in strategic planning and how Phil could play a leadership role.

- Case sourced from Harvard Business Review Press

Case Study 3: The Proposal

Carla, director of strategic planning, thought she was well prepared for her meeting with Shirley, director of the company's newsletter unit. Carla's goal was twofold: to explain plans to form a joint venture with a weekly business magazine and to win Shirley's support. She assumed that Shirley would share her enthusiasm for that venture.

Shirley's icy demeanor should have been a signal that the plan did not sit well with her, but, being wrapped up in her own enthusiasm for the plan, Carla failed to detect the signal as she explained the goal of the joint venture and its details.

"So you can see why we're all very excited about this venture," Carla concluded, "and the opportunity to get broader distribution for some of the newsletter pieces your people put together."

Case Study 3: The Proposal

Shirley paused for a moment and then spoke in a measured tone. “As you know, Carla, our newsletter subscriptions have grown by at least 20 percent per year during each of the past three years. We are doing very, very well.” She leaned forward slightly as she continued. “And the reason for our success is that we have focused on the specific interests of our subscriber base. Are you proposing that we jeopardize that success by shifting gears and writing for a general audience?”

Carla did not have a satisfactory answer for Shirley. She hadn't anticipated her negative attitude toward the joint venture, and so her attempt at communication failed. Worse, she had antagonized an important member of management.

Questions for reflection

What could Carla have done to make this conversation more effective?

How should she have steered this conversation?

Self-reflection

Have you learned anything new from this lesson?

Write down the first thing that comes to your mind. That's your key take-away.

THE END

See you on the discussion forum!